thermonuclear attack. Although JFK had long been interested in protecting the civilian population, when it seemed as if push might come to shove, civil defence was shown to be little more than a shibboleth.

While the evacuation of cities was not feasible, no serious consideration was given to the emergency evacuation plan to ensure the continuity of government. The White House Evacuation Plan called for the President to be taken from the White House to Andrews Air Force Base by helicopter, en route to his underground command centre at Mountain Weather, Virginia.[61] No thought was given to evacuating those members of the government who would occupy a post in the chain of command should the President be killed or incapacitated. Daniel Ellsberg observes, 'a single nuclear warhead on the capital could kill not only the President but all of his legally designated successors in the cabinet and Congress (and the JCS, along with the secretary of defense, the only civilian aside from the President, in the military chain of command) – all of them were in town.'[62]

The possibility of armed conflict between the United States and the Soviet Union was considered as US conventional forces were mobilised in the Caribbean to implement the naval blockade of Cuba and prepare for an invasion of the island. How such conflict might have escalated to nuclear war will be considered in chapter seven.

At no point during the crisis were Cuban forces equipped with nuclear weapons, though anxiety existed in Washington that the MRBMs might be turned over to them (as the United States had handed over IRBMs to several NATO allies). Nor, it should be noted, was serious consideration given by the Kennedy administration to attacking the Soviet missiles with nuclear weapons. What has emerged in recent years, however, is that Moscow apparently decided to provide the Cubans with tactical nuclear weapons. In 1992 Castro said that that if he had possessed such weapons, he would have used them against a US invasion.[63]

President Kennedy's speech of 22 October threatened full-scale nuclear attacks on the Soviet Union in response to an attack on the United States or any other country in the Western hemisphere. There was also an oblique if little-remarked nuclear threat against Cuba. Addressing himself to the 'captive people of Cuba', Kennedy declared: